casting in stark, depressing tones, all over again, the perils young women face in modern settings, in this case exacerbated by the direct hint of powerful people in the mix.

THE MYSTERY 'VIP'

Sanawar's videos became the catalyst. In one clip, she repeated the charge that Ankita was killed for refusing to provide "extra services" to a politician she referred to as "Gattu". In another, she shared an audio clip of what she claimed was a conversation with Rathore, in which he had allegedly named BJP national general secretary and Uttarakhand in-charge Dushyant Gautam in connection with the case. Rathore responded with a press conference, denying the allegations and claiming the audio clip was AI-fabricated. Soon,

Takeaways

- **Unanswered questions in the Ankita Bhandari case spawn fresh protests**
- **A CBI probe begins, but parents, civil society say its terms are vaguely defined**

FIRs were registered against both, including under the IT Act.

Yielding to the public outrage, on January 9, chief minister Pushkar Dhami recommended a CBI investigation into the case. As February dawned, the CBI's Special Crime Branch formally registered a case in Delhi against an "unidentified VIP", taking over the investigation from the state police. On February 2, its team arrived in Uttarakhand to begin the field probe.

This has not calmed the waters. In a letter to the CM, Ankita's father Virendra Bhandari spoke of how everyone is yet to learn the identity of the said 'VIP'. At the mahapanchayat, he and his wife Soni Devi questioned the diluted terms of the CBI inquiry. They demanded an expanded ambit, monitoring by a retired Supreme Court judge, and a scrutiny of all relevant call records.

Even earlier, the case had triggered protests—not the least when the administration dispensed instant 'bulldozer justice' post-murder, razing a portion of the resort. The move became controversial, with allegations that it was an attempt to erase potential evidence. The doubts clearly linger like a raw wound. ■

▶ MADHYA PRADESH

A Running Tap of Questions

The Indore water deaths go under the microscope as a judicial commission reopens the trail of evidence

By **Rahul Noronha**

FOR MADHYA PRADESH, 2026 HAD had a black start. Indore, India's 'cleanest city' for eight consecutive years, was hitting the global headlines—for all the wrong reasons. In late December, after hundreds of complaints about discoloured tap water with a "foul" smell and mass reporting of gastroenteric complaints, the city's Bhagirathpura area began seeing its first deaths. At last count, over 30 residents had lost their lives. After weeks of outrage and hand-wringing, the case has taken a turn that will be watched closely: a full judicial autopsy is on.

A one-man commission of inquiry, headed by retired high court judge S.K. Gupta, has set the ball rolling. On February 9, it invited the public to submit evidence. Till February 28, affected citizens, family members, medical corps, social organisations, contractors, officials or anyone who possesses relevant information can turn it in. This can be complaints over water, photos or videos of pipeline leaks, sewage ingress, tender documents, work orders, inspection reports, medical records, death certificates or any other material record.

The commission is to submit an interim report within four weeks of initiating proceedings. This timeline, likely to keep the case in public spotlight through February-March, was set by the MP High Court. On January 27, ruling on a bunch of public interest litigations, it called for an "urgent judicial scrutiny" while ruling out a purely government-led internal probe. In its submission, the state government had conceded the likelihood of contaminated water being the cause of some deaths; its efforts to flag other possible causes went in vain.

CORRELATION, CAUSATION

By late December, as Bhagirathpura's residents began mass reporting symptoms of gastric disorder and simultaneously noticed their piped water did not even look clean, they didn't take long to correlate the two. December 28, residents say, saw the first death. A day later, municipal water was stopped; tankers moved in. On December 30, the Indore Municipal Corporation (IMC) began investigations. A main water supply pipeline had developed a leak and sewage from a toilet attached to a police